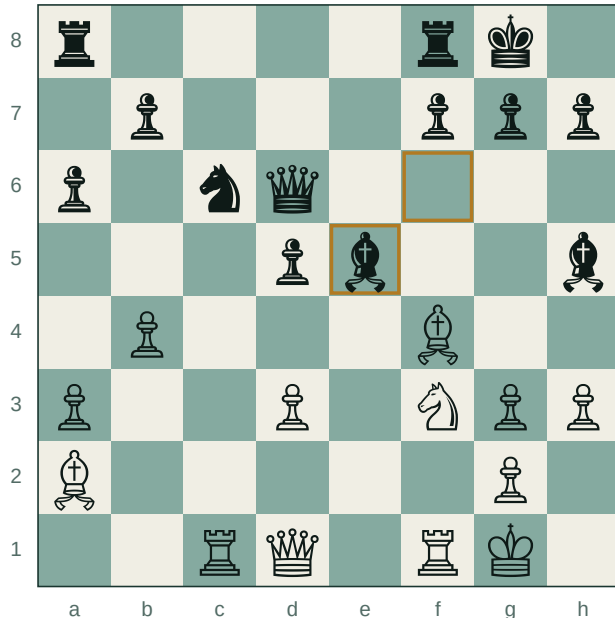


Capture the defender: White, move 21

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 20...Be5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21. Rxc6 Qxc6 22. Bxe5

21.Rxc6 The rook captures the knight on c6. Recorded reply: **21...Qxc6**.

22.Bxe5 The bishop captures the bishop on e5.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 28 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on h5. Check for tactical protection.